The timing of Bharat Jodo cannot be overemphasized. When hate was killing all happiness, the Yatra gave us a ray of hope. It gave ordinary Indians a chance to do something for the nation they loved. They opened their hearts and hearths for us. In Kerala, the Yatra was met with such extraordinary fervour and enthusiasm that it created a sense of insecurity in the ruling party, which was taken aback by how many youngsters organically joined the Yatra. I think the response in Kerala was so overwhelming because the message of the Yatra is a practice deeply embedded in the state's DNA. I think this message of love and fraternity from Bharat Jodo resonated with the masses across the twelve states we walked.

And the Yatra also forced us inside the Congress party to confront our style of working. My father had constantly spurned arm-chair and office politics, and encouraged me to be with the people. But many in the Congress party had got so used to going to Delhi and state capitals or getting attached to leaders to rise in politics that they had forgotten that politics was about the people. But the Yatra turned out to be a blessing for the Congress party. It made each of us engage deeply with our fellow Indians. It made us learn not just how to engage with the masses but also how to be compassionate towards them.

I don't want to paint a rosy picture and say everything in the Yatra was perfect. Many Congresspersons came just to get their or their family's photos clicked with Rahul Gandhi. Some shunned the struggle of the walk. Others would not connect with people outside the Yatra. Some would form bands and stick to the petty politics that every party must grapple with internally. But many yatris were doing a tapasya (austere practice) by following the example of our leader Rahul Gandhi. In fact, I know many worked for months on end, but avoided self-publicity or praise on purpose. Many organizers were working tirelessly to throw open doors for patriotic outsiders who wanted to support the Congress party. Surprisingly, some non-Congress people from civil society who did join the Yatra lost no opportunity to promote themselves. It became a running joke internally that they were even upstaging Jairam Ramesh, the Congress party's official